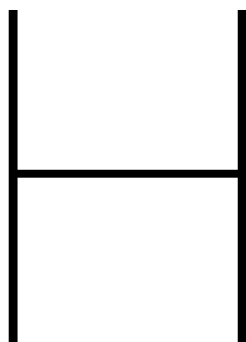


owtime!

As segments within the entertainment sector start to gain scale, the game is well-poised for a big explosion

BY KRISHNA GOPALAN

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HOW DOES ONE differentiate between technology and what is today, in general parlance, called digital? Ask Kiran Mani—the CEO of Viacom18 Digital Ventures—this question and he takes some time to gather his thoughts. “It’s crucial to make a distinction. Technology distributes content, while digital creates a marketplace for it,” he says.

It is a succinct but accurate

assessment, most people would say. Mani, who joined Viacom in late 2023 after 14 years at Google, through this conversation, constantly attempts to simplify what sounds esoteric.

Viacom18’s OTT platform, JioCinema, has been a relatively new entrant in the space but, like in telecommunications, has disrupted the status quo. It left people shocked when it offered the Indian Premier League (IPL) this year free of cost to viewers—at a time when most experts are of the view that subscription is the way to grow the market. “India is undoubtedly a price-sensitive market, and offering the IPL for free was a big bet that we took. When consumers see value, they are willing to pay, as seen in many service industries,” says Mani.

It is hard to disagree with him; a similar playbook has been fol-